

Sounds Good!

Music that fits into your pocket without burning holes

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MP3 players mark a revolutionary stage in the evolution of personal entertainment devices. From the heavenly Apple iPod to their earthly cousins, there is a problem of plenty. It seems as if every manufacturer on earth is making an MP3 player, leaving even informed consumers confused and uncertain. Mediation is at hand though—through these pages we take to task 49 portable music players, and help you pick the best for your needs. Interestingly, all these players can act as regular USB thumb drives to carry your data around. Business with pleasure? You bet!

Our Classification

After some deliberation, we decided to broadly classify the players based on the storage medium—Flash memory and hard drive. Flash-based personal storage media are relatively less expensive, and can easily hold 1GB of data today—the iPod nano packs in 4 GB of Flash storage! Hard disk-based players have higher storage capacities, and are more expensive.



FLASH-BASED PLAYERS

Let's start off with Flash-based players. We received a total of 43 products in this category. Clearly, small is in.

A Look At Features

Barring the Sony Network Walkman (NW) series, all the players we tested are capable of playing MP3 and WMA files. These music files can be just copied onto the player from a PC, without the need for any software. Nearly all the players support a bitrate of up to 340 kbps—

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